Key term
Zionists
Those who advocated the creation of a Jewish homeland and, later, an independent state, in Palestine.

lived some 2000 years before and where several thousands still remained.

Not all Jews wanted to return to the 'Land of Israel'. Most wanted to stay where they were: in France, Britain, Germany, Russia or wherever they were living, but a small number, especially from Russia, made their way to Palestine. They bought land there and started to farm and build homes. These people and all those who believed in a Jewish national homeland were called **Zionists** after Mount Zion, a mountain near Jerusalem. Between 1880 and 1914, 60,000 Zionists settled in Palestine.

Key question
What was the importance of the Balfour Declaration?

Key date
Balfour Declaration: 1917

The Balfour Declaration 1917

During the First World War, British Zionists, led by Chaim Weizmann, worked hard to win the support of the British government for a Jewish homeland. In 1917, they received a great boost. The British were bogged down in the fighting with Germany and they were very keen to bring the USA into the war. They believed that the Jews in America could influence their government's actions. This was one of the reasons why the British government declared its support for a Jewish homeland in Palestine. The declaration was made in the form of a letter to Lord Rothschild, a leading British Jew, in November 1917. It became known as the 'Balfour Declaration' because it was signed by the British Foreign Secretary, Lord Balfour. It stated:

> Foreign Office
> December 2nd, 1917
>
> Dear Lord Rothschild,
>
> I have much pleasure in expressing to you, on behalf of His Majesty's Government, the following declaration of sympathy with Jewish Zionist ambitions. This has been approved by the Cabinet.
>
> 'His Majesty's Government view with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people. The Government will make every effort to help bring this about. It is clearly understood that nothing shall be done which may harm the civil and religious rights of existing non-Jewish communities in Palestine, or the rights and political status enjoyed by Jews in any other country.'
>
> I should be grateful if you would bring this declaration to the knowledge of the Zionist Federation.
>
> [Signed by Lord Balfour]

The British were very careful with their wording of the declaration. They expressed their support for a Jewish homeland, not a state but, for the next 30 years, many Jews regarded the declaration as a promise from the British government to help set up a Jewish state.